Chapter Two: The River Crossing

The ferry had stopped running in the spring, when the water rose over the landing and carried the old rope away, so the family walked the last mile to the ford and waited there for the light to change. Mara counted the stones in the shallows while her brother tied the bundles tighter and their father looked at the far bank as if it might come closer if he stared at it long enough.

They had left the farm four days before, with a cart, two goats and a letter from their uncle that promised work in the mill town on the other side of the hills. The cart had lost a wheel on the second morning, and they had traded it for bread and a pair of boots that fit nobody, and the goats had followed them as far as the crossroads before deciding that they preferred the miller's field to the road.

By the time they reached the river they carried everything they still owned on their backs. Mara had the blankets and the cooking pot, her

brother had the tools, and their father carried the box of papers that he would not let anyone else touch, not even when he slept, which he did badly and seldom.

The river was wider than the stories had made it. It ran brown and quick between banks of grey clay, and in the middle a line of willows stood up to their knees in the current, bending and rising as if they were trying to walk downstream and could never quite decide to go. Their father said that the willows marked the old road, and that a cart could follow them across in a dry summer without wetting its axles.

This was not a dry summer. The rain had come every afternoon for a week, and the water had climbed the clay in dark rings that showed how high it had been the night before. Mara watched a branch go past, turning slowly, and tried to judge how fast it moved, and decided that she did not want to

know.

They waited until the sun was low enough that the glare left the water and they could see the bottom near the bank. Then their father tied a rope around his waist and gave the other end to her brother, and he walked into the river with a long stick in his hand, feeling for the stones of the old road before he trusted any of them with his weight.

He went out slowly, step by step, and the water rose to his knees and then to his waist, and the rope paid out between her brother's hands until it lay across the surface in a long curve that the current pulled downstream. At the third willow he stopped and turned and waved, and his shout came back to them thin and late over the noise of the water, and they understood that the road was still there under the flood and that they would have to follow it.

Her brother went next, carrying the tools above his head, and Mara went

last, with the pot tied to her back and the blankets rolled tight on her shoulders so that they would stay dry for as long as she could keep them out of the water. The stones were slick under her feet. Twice she felt one shift and held the rope with both hands until the river let it settle again, and twice her brother turned to look at her and said nothing, which was the kindest thing he could have done.

In the middle the current was strong enough to lean on. It pressed against her hips like a crowd at a market, steady and careless, and she found that if she leaned into it and kept her feet moving she could cross a stretch of open water between two willows without thinking about the depth at all. She thought instead about the mill town, and the room their uncle had promised, and a bed that did not move.

Halfway across the last stretch her foot came down on nothing. The road ended there, or the flood had taken a stone from it, and for a moment she

hung from the rope with the river pulling at her legs and the pot dragging at her back, and the far bank looked exactly as far away as it had looked from the ford that morning. Then her brother pulled, and her father pulled behind him, and her feet found the next stone, and she walked out of the river onto the clay as if nothing had happened.

They sat on the bank until they stopped shaking. Their father opened the box of papers and found them dry, and he laughed for the first time since they had left the farm, a short surprised sound that made her brother laugh too, and the three of them sat there in the last of the light laughing at a box of papers while the river went on past them as if they had never been in it.

That night they slept in a barn on the edge of a field, with the permission of a woman who asked no questions and brought them a jug of milk and half a loaf without being asked. Mara lay awake for a long time

listening to the rain on the roof and the river somewhere beyond the field, and she thought that she would remember the sound of it for the rest of her life, and she was right.

In the morning the road climbed away from the water into the hills, and they followed it with their wet boots squelching and their bundles lighter for having been wrung out. From the first ridge they could see the river behind them, shining in the early sun, and the line of willows standing in it like a row of people who had stopped halfway across to look back at the road they had come by, and who would stand there until the flood went down.